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The Power of Posting: An Examination of CEO Social Media Celebrity

Ann Mooney[a], **Ruixiang Song**[b] **and Yangyang Zhang**[c]

[a]*Stevens Institute of Technology;* [b]*University of Tennessee–Knoxville;* [c]*Loyola Marymount University*

ABSTRACT The increasing prevalence of social media has prompted discussions regarding its impact on the social evaluations of organizational leaders. In this study, we develop the construct of CEO social media celebrity, which arises when a CEO obtains high levels of attention and positive emotional responses from audiences on social media. Building upon parasocial interaction theory, we examine how a CEO's posting influences their likelihood of becoming a social media celebrity. Analyzing 320 S&P 1500 CEOs on X (formerly Twitter) from 2009 to 2021, who posted over 250,000 times and attracted 1.6 million mentions from social media users, we find that the volume, positivity, and variety of CEO posts relate positively to CEO social media celebrity attainment, while the uniqueness of their posts shows no such effect. [Corrections made on 16 September 2025, after first online publication, the preceding sentence has been updated for clarity in this version.] Additionally, we find evidence suggesting that the nature of the CEO's social media posts relates differently to the two dimensions of CEO social media celebrity (i.e., larger audience attention and positive emotional reactions). We offer suggestions for future research to further enrich the understanding of social evaluations in an increasingly digital world and provide practical insights for CEOs seeking to boost their public profile using social media.

Keywords: CEO celebrity, CEO social media celebrity, parasocial interaction, social evaluation

INTRODUCTION

Over the past two decades, the study of CEO celebrity has emerged as an important area of research in the field of strategic management. Defined as arising when a CEO elicits positive emotional responses from a large public audience (Hayward et al., 2004; Ranft et al., 2006), CEO celebrity research has contributed to the understanding of a range

Address for reprints: Yangyang Zhang, Department of Management, College of Business Administration, Loyola Marymount University, Los Angeles, CA 90045, USA (yangyang.zhang@lmu.edu).

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of outcomes, including strategic choice (Cho et al., 2016), firm performance (Lovelace et al., 2018; Wade et al., 2008), organizational reputation (Ranft et al., 2006), competitor responses (Cho and Choi, 2024), and executive compensation (Graffin et al., 2008; Wade et al., 2006). Progress has also been made in understanding the CEO celebrity attainment, which is understood to hinge on the coverage CEOs receive from mainstream media journalists (Hayward et al., 2004; Lovelace et al., 2018, 2022).

In this study, we examine a distinct type of CEO celebrity – *CEO social media celebrity* – and the factors associated with its likelihood. We define CEO social media celebrity as arising when a CEO obtains high levels of attention and positive emotional responses from audiences on social media. While linkages exist between CEO celebrity and CEO social media celebrity, the social media environment presents unique theoretical mechanisms that influence social evaluations (Roccapriore and Pollock, 2023). CEO celebrity has been found to be driven by mechanisms grounded in media routines that help explain why a relatively limited number of journalists (those from mainstream media outlets) may be drawn to positively and extensively cover a CEO over other CEOs (Lovelace et al., 2022). However, in a social media setting where journalists play a negligible role, the mechanisms are different. They involve why the vast population of social media platform users pay attention and respond positively to CEOs – mechanisms that we argue can be explained by how a CEO's social media posting promotes parasocial interactions, that is, those interactions where users feel connected to a public figure despite largely one-way, non-reciprocated communication (Giles, 2002).

When developing the construct of CEO social media celebrity, we build on research examining how strategic leaders use social media to influence social evaluations. While scholars have focused on how leaders' social media use influences reactions from specific stakeholder groups, such as investors (Chen et al., 2016; Feng and Johansson, 2019) or customer groups (Mangold and Faulds, 2009), other work considers how it influences the social evaluations of broader audiences. For example, Heavey et al. (2020) explained that CEOs can use social media for celebritization by engaging in online behaviours to 'garner attention, seek acclaim, and/or evoke a positive emotional response to their firms, and their own, activities, and decisions' (p. 1504). In a consistent fashion, Lovelace et al. (2022) explained that CEOs can use social media to 'push their way into the limelight by becoming regular sources of information for journalists' stories' (p. 1175). Most recently, Roccapriore and Pollock (2023) tracked the activity of fitness entrepreneurs on Instagram for 6 months and found that the entrepreneurs' communication modes and cues influenced stakeholder engagement on the platform. Their study was especially important in revealing that strategic leaders do not solely use social media to influence the social evaluations of the broad public audience. They may direct their attention to and derive value from focusing within the boundaries of the social media community.

Our research draws insights from studies on social media engagement (Heavey et al., 2020) and CEO celebrity in mainstream media (Lovelace et al., 2022), and follows Roccapriore and Pollock's (2023) approach to focus on social media audiences. We specifically address the question: *How does a CEO's posting activity relate to their becoming a celebrity within the social media platform?* Applying parasocial interaction theory (Giles, 2002), we argue that social media facilitates a novel channel for CEOs to become CEO social media celebrities by communicating with audiences on the

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platform. We hypothesize that the CEO's volume and content of posts (adopting a positive tone, keeping content fresh by posting about a variety of topics, and ensuring content is unique from other CEOs) relate positively to audience attention and positive emotional reactions, that is, CEO social media celebrity. Consistent with how parasocial interaction theory explains that audience members are more likely to be positively drawn to actors who 'break the fourth wall' to communicate with them (Auter, 1992; Levy, 1979), we expect that social media audiences will be positively drawn to CEOs who communicate by posting often and sharing content that resonates with them. We also offer hypotheses about the relative effects of CEO posting activity on the two main drivers of CEO social media celebrity, with posting volume more effective at attracting a higher level of attention and posting content (i.e., positivity, variety, and uniqueness) more effective at evoking positive emotional responses from the audience.

We test our hypotheses using the posting activity of all Standard & Poor's (S&P) 1500 CEOs on the X social media platform (formerly known as Twitter) from 2009 to 2021, which included 320 CEOs who posted over 250,000 times and were mentioned 1.6 million times. Our measure of CEO social media celebrity is based on the volume of attention and the positivity of the emotional response of CEO mentions by all users on the X platform.[1] After controlling for other factors that may contribute to CEO social media celebrity (e.g., already being a CEO celebrity in the mainstream media), our findings support the majority of our hypotheses. Specifically, we find that CEOs' post volume, positivity, and variety are positively associated with becoming social media celebrities. However, contrary to previous research linking distinctiveness with CEO celebrity (Hayward et al., 2004; Lovelace et al., 2022), the uniqueness of a CEO's posts does not contribute to CEO social media celebrity attainment. Finally, we find evidence suggesting that the volume and content of the CEO's social media posts relate differently to the two dimensions of CEO social media celebrity (i.e., attracting audience attention and evoking a positive emotional reaction from them), which we explore further in the discussion section.

Our study makes several theoretical and practical contributions. By developing the construct and measure of CEO social media celebrity and its determinants, we shed more light on how CEOs engage audiences online, which has both research and practical contributions. Our investigation underscores that CEO social media celebrity is not just a repackaging of traditional CEO celebrity rooted in media routines that drive journalists' coverage of CEOs (Lovelace et al., 2022), but rather a fundamentally different phenomenon with distinct attainment processes rooted in parasocial interactions that drive how social media audiences are drawn to a CEO through their posting activity. It is estimated that approximately 4.8 billion people (about 60 per cent of the global population) use social media. While CEOs can have some degree of influence over mainstream media journalists who help set the agenda for public discourse by deciding what to report (Hayward et al., 2004), our study provides both theoretical and practical insights into how CEOs capture the attention and influence the emotional responses of a sizable and growing social media landscape, in which mainstream journalists play a negligible role.

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THEORETICAL BACKGROUND

Mass media has fuelled a fascination with celebrities, creating a global 'celebrity culture' across various fields, including entertainment, sports, and business (Cashmore, 2006). Scholars have taken notice, and an extensive literature on celebrities has developed (Turner, 2010), including a rich stream focused on CEOs who become celebrities (Hayward et al., 2004; Lovelace et al., 2018, 2022; Wade et al., 2006). To further elucidate the new construct of CEO social media celebrity that we introduce in this research, we begin by considering it in relation to the established construct of CEO celebrity.

CEO Social Media Celebrity and CEO Celebrity

We define CEO social media celebrity as arising when the CEO obtains high levels of attention and positive emotional responses from audiences on social media. CEO social media celebrity and CEO celebrity are similar in that they both focus on an audience's attention and emotional reactions.[2] However, as shown in Table I, several factors distinguish the two constructs.

A major difference concerns the target audience, with CEO social media celebrity focused on the social media audience and CEO celebrity focused on a large public audience. The differences in audiences influence the possible actions a CEO can take to affect their likelihood of becoming a celebrity. Social media platforms afford CEOs the opportunity to share information and interact directly, in both real-time and asynchronous fashion, with the active users on the social media platform (Heavey et al., 2020). By contrast, the opportunities for the CEO to influence a large public audience are more diffuse and indirect, and, as discussed above, mainly limited to how CEOs promote themselves to journalists, who serve as key intermediaries that report on CEOs in a largely asynchronous fashion (Lovelace et al., 2022). Another key difference pertains to the role the audiences play in shaping celebrity. Social media users shape CEO social media celebrity with their social media engagement, such as by how they respond to and share content from or about the CEO. By contrast, the broader public audience members play a more passive role in how they consume content developed by mainstream journalists.

While CEO social media celebrity and CEO celebrity often occur together, these conceptual distinctions emphasize that it is possible to attain one but not the other form of celebrity. As we indicate in Table I, there are CEOs who are CEO social media celebrities but not CEO celebrities, such as Thomas Sandgaard, CEO of Zynex, George F. Colony, CEO of Forrester Research, and Lisa W. Wardell, CEO of Adtalem Global Education. For example, Thomas Sandgaard was widely and positively discussed on social media during 2020. Users of the X platform mentioned him 2490 times with largely positive affective language. However, Sandgaard received no coverage in mainstream media during the same period. There are also CEOs who are CEO celebrities but are not CEO social media celebrities, such as Gary C. Kelly, CEO of Southwest Airlines, Hans Vestberg, CEO of Verizon, and Adena T. Friedman, CEO of Nasdaq. For example, Gary C. Kelly was featured in over 30 mainstream media articles in 2020, with the coverage being largely positive. By contrast, Kelly

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Table I. Comparison of CEO social media celebrity and CEO celebrity

	CEO social media celebrity	*CEO celebrity*
Definition	CEO social media celebrity arises when the CEO obtains high levels of attention and positive emotional responses from social media audiences	CEO celebrity arises when the CEO elicits positive emotional responses from a large public audience
Audience	All active social media users on the social media platform	The general public
Intermediaries	No central intermediary. CEOs can interact directly with constituents	There is limited opportunity for direct interaction between the CEO and the general public. Journalists of mainstream media often act as intermediaries. They are incentivized to simplify complex information and create dramatized narratives about the CEO to attract attention
CEO Control and Engagement	CEOs can help shape CEO social media celebrity through their online engagement (e.g., the volume, content, and timing of their posting; interactions with users)	CEOs can help shape CEO celebrity through the way they engage with journalists from mainstream media (e.g., offer interviews, issue press releases)
Audience Engagement	Social media users can shape CEO social media celebrity by how they respond and interact online, whether it be with the CEO or with other users about the CEO	Audience members are more passive consumers of content created and framed by mainstream media journalists
Timing	Communication is asynchronous or in real-time	Communication is almost exclusively asynchronous
Example CEOs	Examples of CEOs who are social media celebrities but not CEO celebrities include: • Thomas Sandgaard, CEO of Zynex; • George F. Colony, CEO of Forrester Research; • Lisa Warner Wardell, CEO of Adtalem Global Education	Examples of CEOs who are CEO celebrities but not CEO social media celebrities include: • Gary C. Kelly, CEO of Southwest Airlines; • Hans E. Vestberg, CEO of Verizon; • Adena T. Friedman, CEO of Nasdaq

attracted comparatively less attention on social media that year. On the X platform, users referred to him in mostly positive ways, but they only mentioned him 340 times.

While scholars have largely not explored CEO social media celebrity, they have shed light on how strategic leaders' online engagement influences social evaluations. CEOs are not immune to the lure of large and expanding social media audiences and are increasingly motivated to start personal accounts to communicate (Etter et al., 2019;

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Heavey et al., 2020). Scholars have largely examined how CEO social media engagement influences social media user reactions to understand its broader impact on specific stakeholders, such as investors (Chen et al., 2016; Feng and Johansson, 2019), journalists, and the general public (Heavey et al., 2020). Regarding celebrity, CEO social media engagement has been linked to CEO celebrity in the mainstream media. While the authors acknowledged that few CEOs had personal social media accounts during their sampling frame (CEOs who started their positions between 2006 and 2010), Lovelace et al. (2022) found that a CEO's prominence on social media – which they aggregated with CEO mentions in press releases to represent CEO self-promotion tactics – related positively to CEO celebrity attainment. Heavey et al. (2020) presented a typology of strategic leaders' social media engagement behaviours enriched with examples they collected from the engagement of 18 CEOs on Twitter. They proposed celebritization as one of six engagement patterns (the others were conveyance, evangelization, discourse, mobilization, and obfuscation) that strategic leaders use to communicate with stakeholders when developing and executing strategy. Other research focuses more squarely on influencing evaluations of the social media environment, such as a study by Roccapriore and Pollock (2023), which explains how the mode and cues of entrepreneurs' communication on Instagram influence stakeholder engagement.

Parasocial Interaction Theory

Just as a major driver of CEO celebrity is the CEO's ability to promote themselves to journalists (Lovelace et al., 2022), a major driver of CEO social media celebrity is the CEO's ability to promote themselves to a large social media audience. However, the nature of communication between CEOs and journalists is often two-way, with CEOs building relationships over time with journalists and ingratiating themselves with them by providing privileged access to information, such as interviews or quotes (Lovelace et al., 2022). By contrast, the communication between the CEO and the social media audience is largely one-way. While CEOs can interact directly with social media users (e.g., replying to their replies), it is not realistic for them to engage with all, or even a significant portion, of the vast social media audience on the platform. Thus, one-way communication is the main pathway by which CEOs promote themselves and influence the likelihood of being social media celebrities.

Initially proposed by Horton and Wohl (1956), parasocial interaction theory sheds light on the mechanisms underlying the effects of CEO communication on a social media audience. Parasocial interactions occur when individuals develop a sense of connection with public figures despite the lack of reciprocation (Giles, 2002; Stever, 2017). Public figures have been shown to promote parasocial interactions by tailoring their communication to create an illusion of a connection with audience members (Tukachinsky et al., 2020). Parasocial interactions can also grow into parasocial relationships, which occur when the individual's sense of connection endures beyond exposure to the public figure, deepening the feeling of a relationship (Tukachinsky et al., 2020) such that the individual perceives the public figure as part of their cultural and social life (Giles, 2002; Hartmann, 2016).

Scholars have studied how parasocial interactions occur with a range of public figures. Perhaps the most well-studied include entertainers (e.g., actors, musicians, comedians)

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and sports figures who attract a large and adoring fan base (Hoffner, 1996; Perse and Rubin, 1989; Rubin et al., 1985). Public figures in business have also been considered, including research on how parasocial relationships form with brand ambassadors (Labrecque, 2014) and CEOs (Liao et al., 2021). While a great deal of the research has examined public figures' communication through more traditional media (e.g., television, movies, public events), scholars have begun to turn their attention to public figures' communication on their personal social media accounts. As explained by Labrecque (2014), parasocial interactions are 'not restricted to traditional mass media but can also be fostered through messages in an online environment that is designed to bring the viewer closer to a mediated persona' and that although 'a direct two-way communication between an individual and the persona is technically possible, consumer–brand interactions on these sites oftentimes more closely mirror one-way conversations' (p. 135).

Parasocial interactions mediated by social media have been found to affect behaviours, including the public figure's social standing (Yuksel and Labrecque, 2016) and personal brand (Ledbetter and Meisner, 2021) on the platform. Brand ambassadors' parasocial interactions with social media users positively affected users' buying intentions (Xiang et al., 2016) and brand perceptions (Labrecque, 2014). Moreover, CEOs' communication style (responsiveness, assertiveness) on social media promoted users' perceptions of CEOs as role models and caring friends, which strengthened their satisfaction with the company and the likelihood that they will advocate for it with others (Tsai and Men, 2017).

Considering parasocial interaction theory in relation to our study, we argue that it helps shed light on how CEOs become social media celebrities. While the literature on CEO celebrity has made significant advances, its focus on journalists as the primary arbiters of celebrity (Hayward et al., 2004; Lovelace et al., 2018, 2022) offers limited theoretical insights for a social media setting where the vast community of social media users is the primary arbiter of celebrity on the platform. As we explore more fully in our hypotheses, parasocial interaction theory provides a lens for understanding how a CEO's posting on social media – both in terms of how much and what they post – influences the size and nature of the attention they receive from active social media users.

HYPOTHESES DEVELOPMENT

Applying parasocial interaction theory, we hypothesize how the CEO's one-way communication (posting) relates to the CEO's social media celebrity. We also hypothesize how the volume and content of the CEO's posts relate differently to the two main social media celebrity drivers – the amount of audience attention and the positivity of their emotional response.

Volume of the CEO's Social Media Posts

The nature of social media enables CEOs to communicate with users as frequently as they want. At the extreme, there are CEOs like Elon Musk, CEO of Tesla and SpaceX, who, even before buying Twitter (now X), averaged over 13 posts a day and recently

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posted as much as 200 times in a given day (Sasa, 2024; Shibu, 2025). Studied in settings such as product branding (Kim et al., 2015) and higher education (Peruta and Shields, 2017), the volume of posts has been found to increase online visibility, drawing the social media audience's attention and encouraging their engagement.

Applied to CEOs, we expect that the volume of posts multiplies the opportunities for the audience to notice and pay attention to the CEO. As we explain below, repeated communication can foster individuals' parasocial interactions with the CEO, which strengthens their emotional connection to the CEO and makes them more likely to advocate for the CEO by sharing the CEO's posts (Tsai and Men, 2017). Such advocacy can expand the amount of attention the CEO receives from social media audiences. Just as Lovelace et al. (2022) explained that the number of posts is a self-promotion tactic CEOs use to push their way into the mainstream media limelight, it is a way for CEOs to push their way into the limelight of the social media platform.

We also expect that the volume of posts will promote positive emotional responses from audiences to the CEO by fostering parasocial interactions and relationships. When posting often, the CEO is engaging in a form of regular, direct (albeit one-way) communication. While a high volume of posts could potentially cause fatigue or discontent among users (Zhang et al., 2022), parasocial interaction theory suggests that it can deepen the connection social media users feel towards the CEO by helping the CEO feel more familiar and accessible. In fact, research in parasocial interaction theory explains that when a public figure communicates regularly with an audience, it can cause bonding in the same way audiences feel more connected to an actor who 'breaks the fourth wall' to speak directly with them (Auter, 1992; Levy, 1979). The CEO's posting volume should also signal that the CEO is accessible because each CEO's post offers users the option to engage (e.g., respond, share, or comment) (Kent, 2010), and there is at least the remote possibility that the CEO might respond (Tukachinsky et al., 2020; Yuksel and Labrecque, 2016). Finally, when leaders post a lot, users may view the time they spend consuming the leader's content as an investment in the leader that they do not want to waste, thereby reinforcing their commitment to the leader (Hall and Davis, 2017). While post volume may not have as strong a relationship with the emotional response of audiences as it does with the amount of the audience's attention – a matter we explore with our fifth hypothesis below – we argue that the net effect will be positive. Thus, we hypothesize:

> *H1:* The greater the volume of the CEO's social media posts, the stronger the likelihood of them being a CEO social media celebrity.

Content of the CEO's Social Media Posts

The effects of social media engagement on social evaluations are influenced not just by the volume but also by the content of the CEO's social media posts. Research suggests that three aspects of the CEO's social media content that should have a bearing on social media celebrity include the positivity, variety, and uniqueness of the CEO's posts (Ashley and Tuten, 2015; Hayward et al., 2004; Pan et al., 2018).

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Positivity. Positive language plays a crucial role in effective communication, including in the context of corporate leaders (Anglin et al., 2018; Pan et al., 2018) and their ability to appeal to stakeholders (Gao et al., 2016; Graffin et al., 2016), such as investors (Huang et al., 2014; Pollock et al., 2023) and employees (Li et al., 2021; Liao et al., 2021). When leaders use positive language, it helps foster parasocial interactions as it deepens a sense of connection with an audience. Individuals have been shown to internalize a CEO's positive messaging, which makes them feel positive about themselves, satisfied at work, interested in paying attention to the leader (Li et al., 2021; Syed et al., 2022), and less anxious (Sobral et al., 2020). A leader's positive language can also evoke a sense of emotional support and psychological safety, similar to the support one receives from a friend or mentor (Inglis and Pascual, 2023), increasing the likelihood that audiences advocate for the leader (Thelen et al., 2022), which should help expand the CEO's audience further.

The CEO's positive content should also help foster parasocial interactions by evoking the audience's positive emotional responses to the CEO. The CEO's positive language enhances the audience's confidence and trust in the CEO (Liao et al., 2021) and increases their likelihood of viewing the CEO as a role model (Tsai and Men, 2017). While not studied with CEOs, parasocial interactions have led individuals to imitate the values and outlook of public figures (Tukachinsky et al., 2020). Coupled with research reporting an online emotional contagion effect (Kramer et al., 2014), we expect that when a CEO strikes a positive tone in social media posts, it will lead to audiences reflecting that positivity back with their emotional reactions to the CEO. Thus, we hypothesize:

> *H2:* The greater the positivity of the CEO's social media posts, the stronger the likelihood of them being a CEO social media celebrity.

Variety. When there is low social media content variety – that is, posting about similar topics – it may become monotonous for audiences, leading them to tune out and feel less connected to the individual posting. By contrast, content variety – that is, keeping content fresh by posting about a variety of topics – conveys at least some new information to the social media audience, which should increase the opportunity for users to relate to the CEO. Content variety should also increase the likelihood that the CEO will post about topics that interest diverse audiences, potentially broadening and increasing the audience drawn to the CEO. Scholars in social media marketing found that regardless of the nature of the content, the variety of content increased the information conveyed, which helped attract consumers and build their emotional attachment to the brand (Sinha et al., 2011). Similarly, the seminal social media marketing study by Ashley and Tuten (2015) found that, contrary to the commonly accepted advertising strategy of sticking with a consistent message, utilizing a variety of message strategies engaged online audiences.

When CEOs vary what they post, social media users may feel a stronger intimacy with the CEO. CEOs have shown a greater tendency to post about both professional (e.g., firm updates) and personal (e.g., beliefs, interests) matters on social media compared to other media (Jameson, 2014). Sharing varied information can promote

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parasocial interactions with audience members because it decreases uncertainty and increases the comfort the audience feels vis-à-vis the public figure (Stever, 2017). Research also suggests that when CEOs share varied information, it allows social media users to feel they know the CEO on a more personal level, perceiving the CEO as a more multidimensional and likable person (Chung and Cho, 2017). Therefore, we hypothesize:

> *H3:* The greater the variety of the CEO's social media posts, the stronger the likelihood of them being a CEO social media celebrity.

Uniqueness. CEOs who engage in distinctive actions that deviate from industry norms are more likely to become CEO celebrities in the mainstream media (Hayward et al., 2004). The rationale is that distinctiveness will help CEOs stand out and be perceived as a 'good story' by journalists who are incentivized to find and shape stories that will interest their audiences (Hayward et al., 2004; Lovelace et al., 2022). Applied to a social media setting, where how one communicates represents behaviours (Heavey et al., 2020), posting unique content – that is, topics that are different from other CEOs – can be viewed as a distinctive action. Thus, just like distinctive actions help CEOs stand out and attract positive attention from journalists, it is plausible that content uniqueness will help CEOs stand out and attract positive attention from the social media audience.

However, given the differences between a social media audience and journalists, the mechanisms by which this occurs differ. When a CEO posts about different topics, it should foster parasocial relationships by helping the CEO stand out from other CEOs and, in turn, command the attention of social media users. Indeed, it is plausible that users will be more curious and emotionally engaged when CEOs depart from the more typical communication (Martin et al., 2022). The CEO's unique content can also help satisfy a commonly held human need for users to be unique themselves (Tian et al., 2011). Users may be drawn to the CEO's unique content because it allows them to stand out from other users who are not familiar with it. They are 'in the know' and may even want to show off that knowledge by sharing the CEO's unique content with others, resulting in larger audience attention to the CEO. Beyond attracting an audience, a CEO's unique content may also promote the impression that they are more transparent and trustworthy, further strengthening parasocial interactions (Jiang and Luo, 2018). Therefore, we expect the following:

> *H4:* The greater the uniqueness of the CEO's social media posts, the stronger the likelihood of them being a CEO social media celebrity.

Relative Effects of Volume and Content of Posts on CEO Social Media Celebrity Dimensions

As we hypothesized, we expect a higher volume of posts and the content of posts (positivity, variety, uniqueness) to relate positively to a CEO becoming a social media celebrity. However, we do not expect them to have the same effects on the two main drivers of social media celebrity – the amount of audience's attention and the positivity of their emotional

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responses. Indeed, the frequency of social media posts should increase visibility and draw more attention from audiences (Kim et al., 2015; Peruta and Shields, 2017). We also expect it may lead to stronger emotional reactions by helping the CEO seem more familiar and accessible. However, research suggests that increased attention will not necessarily be positive and may even be negative depending on how audiences interpret the messaging relative to their own views and identity (Pollock et al., 2019; Zavyalova et al., 2017). In fact, applied to the organizational context, Zavylova and colleagues (2017) explained that rather than celebrity, infamy can be obtained when audience attention is high but their emotional reactions are negative (Zavyalova et al., 2017). According to parasocial interaction theory (Horton and Wohl, 1956), emotional responses depend more on the perceived connection and resonance of the message than on how often the message is delivered. Thus, while the volume of posting may help CEOs attract attention, it may not lead users to feel positively about what CEOs are communicating in their posts. Thus, we hypothesize:

> *H5:* The volume of CEO social media posts will have a stronger positive relationship with the amount of the audience's attention than the positivity of their emotional response to the CEO on social media.

By contrast, we expect the content of the CEO's social media posts to have the opposite relative effects on the two dimensions of CEO social media celebrity. Specifically, we expect that the primary strength of the content of the CEO's posts lies in provoking positive emotional responses from audiences rather than attracting larger audience attention. Consistent with our expectation, Wibowo et al. (2020) found that, with social media marketing, the most impactful social networking content had a stronger effect on enhancing customer relationships and loyalty than on attracting new customers.

As we discussed in more detail above, there are several reasons why different types of content may elicit positive emotional responses from audiences. When a CEO uses positive language, it can be inspirational for social media audiences (Tsai and Men, 2017), leading to stronger confidence and trust in the CEO (Liao et al., 2021). When the CEO makes an effort to share a variety of content, audiences may appreciate it because it keeps their interest and provides opportunities to feel connected with the CEO (Chung and Cho, 2017; Stever, 2017). We also expect that sharing content that is unique from other CEOs will help the CEO appear more authentic (Martin et al., 2022). These positive emotional reactions of the audience to the CEO's post content should help foster their parasocial interactions, facilitating greater familiarity with and admiration for the CEO (Giles, 2002).

Post content may also lead to increased audience attention, but the relationship is indirect. It depends on audiences that respond positively to the CEO's post content advocating for the CEO with others. However, such advocacy does not always occur; it depends on the strength of the parasocial relationships, and it can be influenced by other factors (Tsai and Men, 2017). Thus, we expect that the most salient effects of the CEO's post content (positivity, variety, uniqueness) lie in its effects on emotional reactions. Based on these arguments, we hypothesize:

> *H6:* The (a) positivity, (b) variety, and (c) uniqueness of the CEO's social media posts will have a stronger positive relationship with the positivity of

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the audience's emotional response than the amount of their attention to the CEO on social media.

Taking our hypotheses together, a bigger picture emerges regarding the positive relationships the volume and content of a CEO's social media posts have with CEO social media celebrity. The pathways by which the CEO's post volume and content relate to CEO social media celebrity are more nuanced, such that post volume seems to be more effective at attracting attention, whereas the content of posts seems to be more effective at eliciting positive emotional responses among active social media users. Thus, we argue that posting volume and content complement each other and should be used in tandem to evoke the different dimensions of CEO social media celebrity.

METHODOLOGY

Sample and Data Sources

We used the X accounts of S&P 1500 CEOs to test our hypotheses. Our sample construction began by identifying the X accounts owned by S&P 1500 CEOs. In the first step, we adopted an automated Google search with a query that consisted of the full name of each S&P 1500 CEO included in the ExecuComp database and the keyword 'Twitter'. To ensure the relevance of this search, we retained only the top organic search results for each CEO and avoided results promoted by Google. If the name in the search query was associated with an X account, the search result returned the X profile link of the account. In total, this initial search process yielded 2574 X profiles. Four graduate assistants manually reviewed each X profile to determine if it was indeed owned by the CEO based on publicly available information such as profile pictures, bio sections, and external website links. Based on this review, they classified each CEO's X account as correct, incorrect, or not identifiable. Given X's open and dynamic nature, we adopted a conservative approach in our sample collection process to avoid accounts with pseudonyms or false identities. That is, we eliminated the profile when at least one graduate assistant evaluated the account as an incorrect (i.e., fake) account or an account owned by individuals sharing the same name as the CEO. After validation, we retained the X accounts of 438 CEOs from firms listed in the S&P 1500.

To further validate our verification and ensure we include all active CEOs on X, two authors independently re-examined the sample selection process. This verification involved expanding the search results to the top 10 organic searches for each CEO who did not pair with an X link when using the top one organic search. Then, two authors re-examined all the added search results and X accounts initially labelled as incorrect by graduate assistants. There were 80 accounts labelled as incorrect by both authors, 1034 accounts labelled as not identifiable by both authors, and 1022 accounts with at least incorrect labelling and not identifiable labelling. Then, we conducted a cross-validation of the 1022 accounts with at least incorrect labelling and not identifiable labelling to resolve the difference. There were no instances where one author marked an account as correct

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and another as incorrect. In sum, these additional steps did not result in the identification of any additional CEO Twitter accounts.

We used Twitter Academic API from November 2022 until it became unavailable in February 2023 to systematically retrieve all historical posts from these accounts, replies to these historical posts, along with direct mentions of CEOs between 2009 and 2021.[3] Starting in July 2024, we continued collecting all direct mentions of CEO data between 2009 and 2021 through X's official search interface using Python and proxy rotation. In total, we retrieved over 250 thousand CEO posts, 10.2 million replies to these posts, and 1.6 million direct mentions to the CEO accounts. We aggregated this dataset at the year level and merged the dataset with company data from Compustat, governance data from BoardEx and ExecuComp, and media coverage data from RavenPack. After removing CEOs for which there was missing data, we arrived at a final sample of 320 CEOs and 1250 CEO-year level observations with complete information.

Measures

Dependent variable. We have three dependent variables in our study: (1) CEO social media attention, (2) the positivity of the audience's emotional response CEOs receive on social media, and (3) CEO social media celebrity, which is a composite variable combining the first two variables.

We operationalized *CEO social media attention* using the direct mentions of the CEO's X account from the entire X community. Direct mentions are the independent posts that specifically address or reference the CEO. Thus, these mentions provide insight into how the broad community perceives and engages with the CEO directly. To capture the volume of mentions, we counted the total number of mentions of the CEO's X account each year.

For the *positivity of the audience's emotional response*, we captured the positive emotional responses to the CEO's X account (i.e., direct mentions to the CEO's X account). Consistent with the literature, we used Linguistic Inquiry Word Count (LIWC), a tool validated through a battery of reliability and validity tests[4] (Pennebaker et al., 2015), which assesses emotional resonance of language by counting the words appearing in pre-existing dictionaries developed by psychologists. Applied to our study, this meant we used LIWC to assess the positivity of the emotional response in the post (tweet) that included a direct mention of the CEO's X account. To validate our approach and address potential concerns about using LIWC for short texts, we conducted a cross-validation of posts in our sample (see Appendix for details).

To measure *CEO social media celebrity*, we adopted the approach that was established in prior research on CEO celebrity (Lovelace et al., 2022). As shown in the examples provided in Table II, we created a compound variable by combining the first two dependent variables in our study (i.e., CEO social media attention and the positive emotional response to CEOs on social media). Specifically, we standardized both CEO social media attention and positive emotional response by year to ensure comparability between the variables in each given year.[5] We then multiplied the standardized values to construct our compound measure of CEO social media celebrity. We chose multiplication, rather than addition, because celebrity status arises from the intersection of these two dimensions (Lovelace et al., 2022). Multiplication captures this intersection more accurately, whereas adding the scores can make it hard to tell

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Table II. CEO social media celebrity metrics and example user posts with direct CEO mentions

Year	*CEO identification*	*Std. attention score (A)*	*Std. Pos. emotion score (B)*	*SMC score (A × B)*	*SMC percentile*	*Example X user posts with direct mentions of the CEO*
2011	Fernando Aguirre CEO of Chiquita Brands (@FdoAguirreCEO)	2.65	3.24	8.58	97th	Bummed about @Chiquita news. Feel for @cvggrrl and other friends there. **Thanks** to @FdoAguirreCEO for a **good** run here and **best** of **luck**. **NICE** @FdoAguirreCEO gave a shout out to all of Charlotte's Twitter Followers!: -) What can we say, we're #bananasforCLT! Chiquita CEO @FdoAguirreCEO is very **engaged** on Twitter. It's why we started going #banansforCLT. You should follow him.
2011	Micky Arison CEO of Carnival Corporation (@MickyArison)	2.23	2.97	6.63	95th	I wonder how much David Stern is going to fine @MickyArison for being **honest** on Twitter tonight. God, I **love** you @MickyArison. Don't you ever change for anyone. Just in case you forgot @MickyArison is the freaking **greatest**
2014	James Whitehurst CEO of Red Hat (@Jwhitehurst)	0.57	3.29	1.86	91st	Red Hat CEO @JWhitehurst **shares** his (**inspiring**!) daily routine and schedule Make **sure** to give the world's **greatest** boss @JWhitehurst a follow today! I read too many guides on productivity/efficiency, but these tips from Red Hat CEO @JWhitehurst are **great**.
2015	Marc Benioff CEO of Salesforce (@Benioff)	1.75	3.07	5.36	96th	So **happy** to see people like @Benioff and @MarkZuckerbergF showing **amazing** philanthropic leadership in SF! @benioff Your're my **hero**. **Thank** you Mark @Benioff and Lynne Benioff for your **amazing generosity**. You **inspire** and give **hope** to so many people!
2020	Arvind Krishna CEO of IBM (@ArvindKrishna)	0.80	3.02	2.43	95th	Heartiest Congratulations @ArvindKrishna. Wishing you a **great** and **successful** tenure!! I know @ArvindKrishna to be a moral, ethical and **brilliant** technical leader. I am overjoyed for @IBM! @ArvindKrishna's announcement sending more **positive** ripples.

Note: Positive affective words **bolded** in the post examples.

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apart CEOs who only receive high value in one dimension from those who do in both (Lovelace et al., 2022). Next, we normalized these scores within each year on a 100-point scale by dividing each CEO social media celebrity score by the highest score in that year and multiplying it by 100. We classified the top 10th percentile as social media celebrities and the rest as non-celebrities for that year. We used the top 10th percentile threshold because both attention and emotional response on social media tend to exhibit highly skewed distributions, with a small number of users receiving a disproportionate share (Zhu and Lerman, 2016). Prior celebrity studies have used the 25th percentile to distinguish celebrities and non-celebrities (Hubbard et al., 2018; Pfarrer et al., 2010). In an untabulated analysis, we found that our results are robust when using the 25th percentile as the cutoff, except that content variety becomes insignificant in predicting social media celebrity. In our final sample, 44 out of 320 CEOs achieved social media celebrity in at least 1 year. Of these, 21 CEOs were social media celebrities for a single year, while those with multiple years averaged 4.17 years as a social media celebrity.

Independent variables. We measured *the volume of CEO social media posts* as the number of initial posts made by a CEO in each year. By initial, we refer to when a CEO starts a conversation thread on X, not when they respond to others or themselves. Thus, this variable is the proxy for the intensity of their activities on X in a given year, such that a higher number of posts in a given year was indicative of a more frequent posting pattern by the CEO. For ease of interpretation, we scaled this variable in thousands.

The positivity of the CEO's social media posts refers to the use of more positive language than negative language in a CEO's post. We measured this variable using the affective word lists from LIWC. We quantified the number of affective words in each CEO's posts and determined the positivity value as the percentage of positive affective words out of all affective words (i.e., positive plus negative affective words) in each CEO's posts within a given year.

The variety of the CEO's social media posts indicates how much each initial post from a CEO deviates from the general trend of their own posts over the year. We use BERTweet (Nguyen et al., 2020), an X-specific adaptation of the BERT model, to measure the content of CEO posts. This model has been trained on a corpus of 850 million English posts, encompassing approximately 16 billion-word tokens. This extensive training enables BERTweet to interpret the complexities and idiosyncrasies of X language effectively. We processed each post in our sample through BERTweet to transform the textual data into high-dimensional vector space representations. Then, we applied mean pooling to these vectors to create a single vector representation for each CEO per year. As the centroid point of all posts the CEO has posted in that year, this single vector representation should represent a consolidated year-level profile for each CEO based on the content they posted in this timeframe. After yielding the pooled vector for each CEO in each year, we calculate the average cosine similarity between each CEO post and the centroid of their pooled vector for the same year. We reverse-coded this measure by subtracting it from 1. This variable ranges from 0 to 1, with 0 meaning completely similar and 1 meaning completely dissimilar within each pool of posts by a CEO in a year. We standardized this variable by year to facilitate interpretation.

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The uniqueness of the CEO's social media posts reflects the level of differentiation in a CEO's initial posts when compared to the collection of posts from all CEOs on X in the same year. We relied on the high-dimensional vector space representations from BERTweet as the basic unit for this measurement as well. Specifically, we applied mean pooling to all CEO-level vectors in each year to another single vector representation to represent a consolidated year-level content profile for all CEOs. Content uniqueness is then measured by calculating the cosine similarity between the centroid of the post vector by a CEO and the centroid of the mean pooled vector of all CEOs in the same year. We also reverse-coded this measure by subtracting it from 1 to provide a measure of how the content profile of a CEO diverges from the broader pattern of all CEO posts on the same social media platform. This measure also ranges from 0 to 1, with higher values indicating greater divergence from the platform-wide CEO posting patterns. To ensure comparability across different years, each measurement was standardized by year. This standardization accounted for variations in posting behaviour, language use, and overall platform dynamics over time, allowing for a more accurate year-over-year comparison of content.

Control variables. We control for *CEO celebrity* with the broad mainstream media. Following Lovelace et al. (2022) and Pollock et al. (2023), we measured this variable by considering the volume of attention and the positive emotional responses of that attention received by CEOs. To collect this data, we first conducted a comprehensive search of news articles about all S&P 1500 CEOs from 2009 to 2021 using LexisNexis. The count of these articles served as the primary indicator for gauging the volume of attention. We narrowed down to three types of news sources: newspapers, news transcripts, and magazines and journals. Next, we narrowed down our searches by filtering the sources of the news articles. For newspapers, we selected the top 10 US newspapers, including the Wall Street Journal, New York Times, USA Today, Washington Post, Los Angeles Times, New York Post, Tampa Bay Times, Chicago Tribune, Newsday, and Star Tribune. For business magazines, we selected Bloomberg Businessweek, Bloomberg TV, Forbes, Fortune, Fast Company, and The Economist. Finally, we focused on prominent broadcast news outlets, including ABC, NBC, CBS, FOX, MSNBC, CNBC, PBS, and NPR. In addition, we incorporated data from Wikipedia to construct our attention measure. We counted the number of Wikipedia page views and the number of edits for each CEO year to capture the size of the attentive audience of each CEO from online media. We standardized each indicator by year and then added them together to generate an overall volume of media attention score for each CEO in a given year (Lee et al., 2011; Lovelace et al., 2022).

Aligned with our primary dependent variable, for the positivity of the emotional responses component, we used LIWC to capture the emotional resonance and the relative positivity of every newspaper article, magazine article, and broadcast transcript in the above-mentioned counts. Following Lovelace et al.' (2022) approach, the CEO celebrity variable was developed based on the two components (attention and the positivity of emotional responses) following the steps below. First, we rescaled both the attention and positive emotional response score for each year by adding 0.01 plus the positive value of the lowest score observed that year to ensure all values were

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positive and non-zero. Next, we multiplied the revised value of the attention and positive emotional response scores. Finally, we normalized the scores within each year on a 100-point scale. This involved dividing each *level of attention* × *positivity of emotional responses* score by the highest score for a CEO in that year and multiplying it by 100. Consequently, the CEO with the largest score for that year was assigned a score of 100, while all other CEOs received proportional scores on the 100-point scale for that year. Then, we treated the top 10th percentile of CEOs within the entire S&P 1500 sample as celebrities (25th percentile in a robustness check) and the rest as non-celebrities in our analyses. If a CEO was a celebrity in the given year, we code them as one; otherwise, it receives zero.

We controlled for *CEO social media experience* by including the number of years since the CEO established their X account. We also controlled for *CEO thread engagement*, which is measured as the number of self-replies by CEOs to their original posts. On X, accounts with a large follower base are likely to receive more attention than those with a small follower base. While we could not retrieve historical numbers of CEO across our sampling period due to data availability, we controlled for the *number of replies* per CEO post to reflect the relative engagement their posts generate.[6] We controlled for *firm mentions of CEO*, measured as the number of direct mentions of the CEO from their firm X accounts.

As for firm-level factors, we controlled for *firm size* and *firm performance* because firm size and performance are tied to the performance of a CEO, which might impact individual evaluation of the CEO (Wiersema and Zhang, 2011). We measured firm size as a natural log of sales and firm performance as return on equity for the firm that the CEO served in a given year (Finkelstein and Boyd, 1998; Johnson and Greening, 1999). In addition, we controlled for *firm media coverage* because, as one of the main sources of information, media can effectively shape the perception of firms and their CEOs (Graf-Vlachy et al., 2020). We used RavenPack to measure media coverage (Connelly et al., 2017). RavenPack is a data platform that offers analytics on published content from a wide range of sources, such as Dow Jones Newswires, Wall Street Journal, Barron, and over 40,000 web-based sources. Previous research has used RavenPack to collect data on firm actions (Connelly et al., 2019), event analytics (Chen et al., 2021), and news sentiment (Um et al., 2022). To obtain the coverage measure from the media towards firms, we started with a two-step filtering process. First, we exclusively considered data entries that pertain to news articles obtained from all published documents on RavenPack. Second, we narrowed down the selection to news articles that had a relevance score of 100 and featured direct mentions of the entity under investigation, thereby verifying the centrality of the entity in the news. After the identification of all relevant news articles, we measured media coverage as the number of news articles about a firm in a given year and media sentiment using the Janis-Fadner coefficient of imbalance among favourable, unfavourable, and neutral coverage (Janis and Fadner, 1965; Pollock and Rindova, 2003). Lastly, at the CEO level, we controlled for CEO *age*, *gender*, and *race* to account for possible relationships between these factors and their evaluations (Westphal and Zajac, 1995). *CEO gender* is coded as 1 for female and 0 for male, and *CEO race* is coded as 1 for white and 0 for non-white.

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Table III. Correlations and descriptive statistics

		Mean	*SD*	*1*	*2*	*3*	*4*	*5*	*6*	*7*	*8*	*9*	*10*	*11*	*12*	*13*	*14*	*15*	*16*	*17*	*18*
1.	CEO social media celebrity	0.09	0.29																		
2.	CEO celebrity	0.24	0.43	0.37																	
3.	Number of CEO mentions[a]	0.00	1.01	0.51	0.28																
4.	Positive emotional response of CEO mentions[a]	0.01	0.99	0.11	0.04	0.03															
5.	Volume of CEO posts ($\times 10^3$)	0.20	0.55	0.27	0.12	0.24	0.12														
6.	Positivity of CEO posts	0.84	0.22	0.06	0.04	0.00	0.25	0.01													
7.	Variety of CEO posts[a]	0.00	1.00	0.07	0.06	0.07	0.04	0.12	−0.02												
8.	Uniqueness of CEO posts[a]	0.01	1.00	−0.08	−0.06	−0.04	−0.22	−0.11	−0.25	0.00											
9.	CEO social media experience	4.80	3.09	0.10	0.08	0.09	0.12	0.16	0.08	0.08	−0.18										
10.	CEO thread engagement	5.35	34.40	−0.04	−0.05	−0.02	0.07	0.39	−0.01	0.12	−0.02	0.14									
11.	Number of the replies	17.45	188.52	0.17	0.15	0.41	0.00	0.05	−0.07	−0.07	0.02	0.02	−0.01								
12.	Firm mentions of CEO	16.55	34.01	0.22	0.07	0.06	0.21	0.18	0.11	0.08	−0.16	0.13	0.01	−0.02							
13.	Firm size[b]	7.63	1.60	0.31	0.33	0.20	0.06	0.10	0.19	−0.01	0.02	−0.08	−0.06	0.11	0.07						
14.	Firm performance	0.18	0.23	0.04	−0.02	−0.03	0.01	−0.08	0.11	0.02	0.02	−0.09	−0.07	0.00	−0.01	0.31					
15.	Firm media coverage[b]	6.70	2.63	0.27	0.20	0.20	0.05	−0.09	0.10	0.03	−0.09	0.03	−0.16	0.12	0.09	0.20	0.09				
16.	Firm media sentiment	0.38	0.20	0.17	0.08	0.02	0.05	−0.07	0.11	0.02	−0.03	0.06	−0.12	0.03	0.12	0.15	0.11	0.55			
17.	CEO age	52.90	6.97	0.04	0.04	−0.01	−0.01	−0.01	0.05	0.01	0.05	0.01	0.02	−0.06	−0.01	0.26	0.15	0.01	−0.04		
18.	CEO gender	0.08	0.27	0.00	0.07	−0.04	0.05	−0.03	0.11	0.00	−0.01	0.02	−0.03	−0.02	0.07	0.00	0.00	0.04	0.02	−0.03	
19.	CEO race	0.87	0.34	−0.09	−0.07	0.01	−0.08	−0.05	0.00	0.02	0.03	−0.06	0.05	0.03	−0.06	−0.01	0.02	0.02	−0.05	0.09	0.01

Note: N = 1250. Absolute value of correlation greater than 0.055 at $p < 0.05$ level for two-tailed tests.
[a]Standardized values reported by year.
[b]Values reported in natural log.

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We present descriptive statistics and correlations for all variables in Table III. The mean variance inflation factor among all predictors is 1.21, and none of the control variables has a value above 2, which suggests that multicollinearity is unlikely to be a concern for modelling.

Analytical Considerations

Logit regression analysis. We used logit regression analysis to examine the likelihood of CEOs social media celebrity each year (H1 to H4). The key predictors in this analysis include the volume of the CEO's social media posts, as well as the positivity, variety, and uniqueness of the CEO's social media posts. In this analysis, we included the full set of control variables along with year and industry fixed effects. We also applied robust standard errors to address concerns related to the non-independence of observations. In this analysis, 286 observations were excluded due to complete separation within industry groups. However, the results remain largely robust with the full 1250 observations in a penalized maximum likelihood regression, except that positivity of CEO posts becomes insignificant, with a p-value of 0.34.

Seemingly unrelated regressions. In Hypotheses 5 and 6, we focus on the relative effects of key predictors on *CEO social media attention* and *positivity of the audience's emotional response*. We used seemingly unrelated regressions (SUR), a multivariate technique that estimates multiple regression equations simultaneously while explicitly accounting for potential correlation in error terms across these equations. Thus, this approach can help facilitate the direct comparison of coefficient estimates of the same independent variables across different dependent variables. Specifically, we first included the same set of predictors to estimate their effects on the level and emotional response of audience attention separately. We then conducted a chi-square test to compare the effects of the predictors between the two equations. Both equations included a full set of control variables to account for potential confounding factors. We also included year and industry fixed effects and robust standard errors to address potential non-independence.

RESULTS

We show the results of our hypothesis testing in Tables IV and V. Models 1–6 in Table IV are the logit regression models. Model 1 is a control-only model; Models 2–5 each include one independent variable, and Model 6 is the fully saturated model. Because probit/logit models are non-linear, the effect of a unit change in an explanatory variable does not equal the variable's model coefficient. It varies over all values of variables. To facilitate the interpretation, we included the average marginal effects (AMEs; Hoetker, 2007), which represent the change in probability associated with an increase in the dependent variable by 1 unit while all other variables remain at their mean value (STATA procedure MARGINS, DYDX was used in computing AMEs).

In Hypothesis 1, we predict that the volume of CEO social media posts is positively associated with the likelihood of a CEO being a social media celebrity. In Model 6 of Table IV, the coefficient estimate of *volume of the CEO's social media posts* is positive and statistically significant ($\beta = 2.32$, $p < 0.01$), and the average marginal effects indicate that, on

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Table IV. Logit regression predicting CEO social media celebrity

	Model 1		*Model 2*		*Model 3*		*Model 4*		*Model 5*		*Model 6*	
	CEO social media celebrity											
Variables	β	*AME*	β	*AME*	β	*AME*	β	*AME*	β	*AME*	β	*AME*
H1. Volume of CEO posts ($\times 10^3$)			2.25***	0.11***							2.32***	0.11***
			[0.50]	[0.02]							[0.54]	[0.02]
H2. Positivity of CEO posts					1.45*	0.08*					1.98*	0.09*
					[0.82]	[0.05]					[1.07]	[0.05]
H3. Variety of CEO posts							0.37**	0.02**			0.44**	0.02**
							[0.16]	[0.01]			[0.20]	[0.01]
H4. Uniqueness of CEO posts									−0.38	−0.02	−0.17	−0.01
									[0.23]	[0.01]	[0.19]	[0.01]
CEO celebrity	1.56***	0.10***	1.44***	0.09***	1.58***	0.10***	1.54***	0.10***	1.47***	0.10***	1.37***	0.08***
	[0.29]	[0.02]	[0.31]	[0.02]	[0.29]	[0.02]	[0.29]	[0.02]	[0.30]	[0.02]	[0.31]	[0.02]
CEO social media experience	0.16**	0.01***	0.10	0.00	0.17**	0.01***	0.16**	0.01**	0.15**	0.01**	0.10	0.00
	[0.06]	[0.00]	[0.07]	[0.00]	[0.06]	[0.00]	[0.07]	[0.00]	[0.07]	[0.00]	[0.07]	[0.00]
CEO thread engagement	−0.00	0.00	−0.03	0.00	−0.00	0.00	−0.00	0.00	−0.00	0.00	−0.04	0.00
	[0.01]	[0.00]	[0.05]	[0.00]	[0.01]	[0.00]	[0.01]	[0.00]	[0.02]	[0.00]	[0.06]	[0.00]
Number of replies	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00**	0.00**
	[0.00]	[0.00]	[0.00]	[0.00]	[0.00]	[0.00]	[0.00]	[0.00]	[0.00]	[0.00]	[0.00]	[0.00]
Firm mentions of CEO	0.02***	0.00***	0.01***	0.00***	0.02***	0.00***	0.02***	0.00***	0.02***	0.00***	0.01***	0.00***
	[0.00]	[0.00]	[0.00]	[0.00]	[0.00]	[0.00]	[0.00]	[0.00]	[0.00]	[0.00]	[0.00]	[0.00]
Firm size	0.57***	0.03***	0.46**	0.02**	0.55***	0.03***	0.62***	0.03***	0.62***	0.03***	0.51**	0.02**
	[0.20]	[0.01]	[0.19]	[0.01]	[0.20]	[0.01]	[0.21]	[0.01]	[0.20]	[0.01]	[0.22]	[0.01]

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Table IV. (Continued)

	Model 1		*Model 2*		*Model 3*		*Model 4*		*Model 5*		*Model 6*	
	CEO social media celebrity											
Variables	β	*AME*	β	*AME*	β	*AME*	β	*AME*	β	*AME*	β	*AME*
Firm performance	−1.00*	−0.05*	−0.62	−0.03	−1.03*	−0.06*	−1.20**	−0.06**	−1.06*	−0.06**	−0.93	−0.04
	[0.54]	[0.03]	[0.55]	[0.03]	[0.55]	[0.03]	[0.55]	[0.03]	[0.54]	[0.03]	[0.59]	[0.03]
Firm media coverage	0.41	0.02*	0.43*	0.02*	0.43	0.02*	0.39	0.02	0.40	0.02	0.42*	0.02*
	[0.26]	[0.01]	[0.24]	[0.01]	[0.27]	[0.01]	[0.25]	[0.01]	[0.27]	[0.01]	[0.24]	[0.01]
Firm media sentiment	2.56***	0.14***	2.89**	0.14***	2.55**	0.14***	2.67***	0.14***	2.57**	0.14***	3.02**	0.14***
	[0.99]	[0.05]	[1.13]	[0.05]	[1.00]	[0.05]	[1.03]	[0.05]	[1.01]	[0.05]	[1.21]	[0.05]
CEO age	0.05**	0.00**	0.07***	0.00***	0.05**	0.00**	0.04*	0.00*	0.05**	0.00**	0.08**	0.00**
	[0.02]	[0.00]	[0.03]	[0.00]	[0.02]	[0.00]	[0.02]	[0.00]	[0.02]	[0.00]	[0.03]	[0.00]
CEO gender	−0.79	−0.04	−0.51	−0.02	−0.89	−0.04	−0.71	−0.03	−0.67	−0.03	−0.48	−0.02
	[0.78]	[0.03]	[0.78]	[0.03]	[0.79]	[0.03]	[0.75]	[0.03]	[0.76]	[0.03]	[0.78]	[0.03]
CEO race	−0.74**	−0.04**	−0.68**	−0.04*	−0.70**	−0.04**	−0.72**	−0.04**	−0.68**	−0.04**	−0.54	−0.03
	[0.32]	[0.02]	[0.35]	[0.02]	[0.33]	[0.02]	[0.32]	[0.02]	[0.32]	[0.02]	[0.36]	[0.02]
Constant	−12.34***		−21.51***		−13.50***		−12.42***		−13.27***		−24.02***	
	[2.64]		[3.72]		[2.79]		[2.66]		[2.88]		[4.12]	
Year FE	YES		YES		YES		YES		YES		YES	
Industry FE	YES		YES		YES		YES		YES		YES	
Observations	964		964		964		964		964		964	
Pseudo R-squared	0.498		0.540		0.500		0.504		0.502		0.551	
Log-likelihood	−179.0		−164.0		−178.3		−176.6		−177.4		−159.9	

Note: Robust standard errors in brackets.
***p < 0.01; **p < 0.05; *p < 0.10.

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Table V. Seemingly unrelated regressions predicting social media attention

Variables	*Model 1* *Number of CEO mentions*	*Model 2* *Positive emotional response of CEO mentions*	*Chi-squared test*	
H1. Volume of CEO posts ($\times 10^3$)	0.37***	0.06*	H5	6.76***
	[0.12]	[0.03]		
H2. Positivity of CEO posts	0.09	0.93***	H6a	21.91***
	[0.10]	[0.14]		
H3. Variety of CEO posts	0.06**	0.02	H6b	0.89
	[0.02]	[0.03]		
H4. Uniqueness of CEO posts	−0.01	−0.11***	H6c	6.31**
	[0.02]	[0.03]		
CEO celebrity	0.23***	−0.02		
	[0.05]	[0.06]		
CEO social media experience	0.02***	0.02*		
	[0.01]	[0.01]		
CEO thread engagement	−0.00***	0.00***		
	[0.00]	[0.00]		
Number of replies	0.00*	0.00		
	[0.00]	[0.00]		
Firm mentions of CEO	0.00	0.00***		
	[0.00]	[0.00]		
Firm size	0.06***	0.04		
	[0.02]	[0.02]		
Firm performance	−0.29**	−0.02		
	[0.13]	[0.13]		
Firm media coverage	0.06***	0.01		
	[0.01]	[0.01]		
Firm media sentiment	−0.21	0.08		
	[0.16]	[0.16]		
CEO age	0.01	0.00		
	[0.00]	[0.00]		
CEO gender	−0.36***	0.11		
	[0.10]	[0.08]		
CEO race	−0.01	−0.08		
	[0.04]	[0.07]		
Constant	−1.79***	−0.78**		
	[0.55]	[0.39]		
Year FE	YES	YES		

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Table V. (Continued)

Variables	*Model 1* *Number of CEO mentions*	*Model 2* *Positive emotional response of CEO mentions*	*Chi-squared test*
Industry FE	YES	YES	
Observations	1250	1250	
Log-likelihood	−3038	−3038	
Pseudo R-squared			
R-squared	0.43	0.22	

Note: Robust standard errors in brackets.
***p < 0.01;
**p < 0.05;
*p < 0.10.

average, each one-unit increase (a thousand posts) in volume in a given year is associated with an 11 per cent increase in the likelihood of being a social media celebrity in that year. Thus, Hypothesis 1 is supported.

In Hypothesis 2, we predict that the positivity of the CEO's posts is positively associated with the likelihood of being a CEO social media celebrity. In Model 6 of Table IV, the coefficient estimate of *the positivity of the CEO's social media posts* is positive and marginally significant ($\beta = 1.98$, $p < 0.10$), and the average marginal effects indicate that, on average, each standard deviation increase in positivity in a year is associated with a 9 per cent increase in the likelihood of social media celebrity in that year. Thus, Hypothesis 2 is marginally supported.

In Hypothesis 3, we predict that the variety of a CEO's posts is positively associated with the likelihood of being a CEO social media celebrity. In Model 6 of Table IV, the coefficient estimate of *the variety of the CEO's social media posts* is positive and statistically significant ($\beta = 0.44$, $p < 0.05$), and the average marginal effects indicate that, on average, each standard deviation increase in variety in a year is associated with a 2 per cent increase in the likelihood of being a CEO social media celebrity in that year. Thus, Hypothesis 3 is supported.

In Hypothesis 4, we predict that the uniqueness of a CEO's social media posts is positively associated with the likelihood of being a CEO social media celebrity. In Model 6 of Table IV, the coefficient estimate of *the uniqueness of the CEO's social media posts* is negative but statistically insignificant ($\beta = -0.17$, *n.s.*). Thus, we failed to find evidence to support Hypothesis 4 and provide insights for this non-finding in our Discussion section.

In Hypothesis 5, we predict that the volume of CEO social media posts will have a greater positive effect on attention level (number of CEO mentions) than on the positivity of emotional responses. Results from Model 1 of Table V show that the coefficient estimate of *the volume of CEO social media posts* is positive and significant ($\beta = 0.37$, $p < 0.01$) when predicting the volume (i.e., number) of CEO mentions. In comparison, the results from Model 2 in Table V show that the coefficient estimate is positive but only marginally significant ($\beta = 0.06$, $p < 0.10$) when predicting the positive emotional responses to CEO

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mentions. We compare these two coefficient estimates using a chi-squared test. The results show the difference between the two estimates is statistically significant ($\chi^2 = 6.76$, $p < 0.01$), which indicates that *the volume of CEO social media posts* has a stronger positive effect on the number of CEO mentions than on the positive emotional responses of CEO mentions. Thus, we find support for Hypothesis 5.

In Hypothesis 6, we expect that the positivity (H6a), variety (H6b), and uniqueness (H6c) of the CEO's social media posts will all have a stronger positive effect on the positive emotional responses of CEO mentions than the number of CEO mentions. For 6a, as shown in Models 1 and 2 of Table V, the coefficient estimates of *positivity of CEO social media posts* are positive and statistically significant ($\beta = 0.93$, $p < 0.01$) when predicting the positive emotional responses of CEO mentions and not statistically significant ($\beta = 0.09$, *n.s.*) when predicting the number of CEO mentions. The results of the chi-squared test show that the difference between these two estimates is statistically significant ($\chi^2 = 21.91$, $p < 0.01$). These results are consistent with the prediction in hypothesis 6a.

As for hypothesis 6b referring to the variety of a CEO's social media posts, results from Models 1 and 2 of Table V reveal a positive yet statistically insignificant association with the positive emotional responses of CEO mentions ($\beta = 0.02$, *n.s.*) and a positive and significant association with the number of CEO mentions ($\beta = 0.06$, $p < 0.05$). A chi-squared test indicates no significant difference between these coefficient estimates across models ($\chi^2 = 0.89$, *n.s.*), which is inconsistent with prediction of hypothesis 6b. We consider this non-finding in our Discussion section.

Regarding hypothesis 6c referring to the uniqueness of a CEO's social media posts, the results from Models 1 and 2 of Table V indicate that uniqueness is negatively related to the positive emotional responses of CEO mentions ($\beta = -0.11$, $p < 0.01$) and not related to the number of CEO mentions ($\beta = -0.01$, *n.s.*). While a chi-squared test reveals a significant difference between these coefficient estimates across models ($\chi^2 = 6.31$, $p < 0.05$), the direction suggests uniqueness has a stronger negative effect on positive emotional responses of CEO mentions than the number of CEO mentions, which contradicts our prediction for hypothesis 6c, as we discuss further in our discussion section.

Finally, while not a hypothesized effect, we note interesting findings with CEO gender. As we discuss later, we do not find a significant association between CEO gender and CEO social media celebrity, but we do observe a negative and significant relationship between CEO gender and the number of CEO mentions in Model 1. However, this association is absent in Model 2 when predicting the positive emotional response to CEO mentions. This may suggest that although CEO gender does not significantly influence becoming a social media celebrity, female CEOs tend to receive fewer mentions than male CEOs.

Robustness Check

To address endogeneity concerns, we considered the Lewbel method, which exploits model heteroskedasticity to generate internal instruments and is particularly useful in situations where external instrumental variables are difficult to identify. Our primary dependent

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variable, CEO social media celebrity, is dichotomous and thus does not satisfy the linearity assumptions required for the Lewbel approach. Thus, we conducted this robustness check using a normalized score based on the product of the number of CEO mentions and the positive emotional response of CEO mentions as an alternative continuous dependent variable. In untabulated results, we found that all main findings remained consistent. Additionally, we observed a significant and negative association between content uniqueness and CEO social media celebrity ($\beta = -0.48$, $p < 0.05$). Thus, in addition to confirming the results from our main analysis, the significant and negative effect of content uniqueness observed with the continuous measure suggests that this specification provides statistical power to detect nuanced effects of content uniqueness that may be obscured with a binary measure of CEO social media celebrity.

In our main analysis, we consider the effects of the positivity of a CEO's social media posts. However, positivity and negativity operate on separate spectrums, which means they may exert different effects on the likelihood of CEO social media celebrity. Thus, in a robustness check, we separately calculate both the positive and negative percentages of all emotional words, as well as the percentage of all non-emotional words in the entire corpus of posts (i.e., neutral words) from a CEO in a year. Similarly, in addressing multicollinearity between these variables, we orthogonalize them before including them in the analysis. We present the results of this analysis in the Appendix (see Table A1). In Model 1, we find that the positivity of a CEO's social media posts has a positive and significant association with the likelihood of CEO social media celebrity ($\beta = 9.84$, $p < 0.01$), consistent with our main findings. Yet, we find that the negativity of a CEO's social media posts is also significantly and positively correlated with CEO social media celebrity ($\beta = 5.35$, $p < 0.01$). In addition, in Models 2 and 3, the results show that CEO post negativity is only significantly associated with number of CEO mentions ($\beta = 0.06$, $p < 0.01$) but not with positive emotional responses of CEO mentions ($\beta = -0.00$, *n.s.*). These results suggest that negative content may attract attention that potentially leads to CEO social media celebrity, even if it does not necessarily influence the overall emotional responses of this attention. We speculate that this is because negativity can often evoke strong emotional reactions, aligning with the perspective of negativity bias (the tendency for humans to focus more on negative information), and can drive controversy or debate, which amplifies visibility.

Supplemental Analysis

In this study, we focus on factors leading to CEO social media celebrity. Despite the difference in its nature and implication, it is reasonable to ask whether CEOs who are social media celebrities will be more likely to be celebrities in mainstream media outlets. To explore this possibility, we use a generalized structural equation model (GSEM) approach to examine the mediating role of CEO social media celebrity in translating digital engagement into traditional media recognition. To strengthen causal inference in modelling the relationship, we shift CEO celebrity forward by 1 year, because using a 1-year lag mitigates concerns about reverse causality with temporal ordering. Our results remain robust when this forward shift is not applied. As shown in the Appendix (Table A2), the results reveal a positive relationship between CEO social media celebrity and the likelihood of CEO celebrity in the mainstream

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media ($\beta = 0.95$, $p < 0.05$). The results also show that two of our key predictors – the post volume of CEO social media posts and variety of CEO social media posts – have marginally significant indirect effects on CEO celebrity from mainstream media. However, we failed to find evidence to confirm the direct effects of these variables on CEO celebrity from mainstream media. This result suggests there is likely a complete mediation through CEO social media celebrity, meaning the volume and the variety of a CEO's social media posts are all likely to influence the likelihood of CEO celebrity in the traditional media through their impact on social media celebrity.

DISCUSSION

We contribute to the literature on social evaluations by introducing, defining, and developing a measurement for CEO social media celebrity and examining its antecedents. Through our theoretical arguments and empirical tests, we emphasize that focused attention on CEO social media celebrity is important. While significant advances have been made in understanding CEO celebrity in the mainstream media, its emphasis has been on journalists as the central intermediary between CEOs and audiences (Hayward et al., 2004; Lovelace et al., 2018, 2022). Moreover, although scholars have provided insights into CEO social media engagement, the focus has largely been on the CEO's use of social media to influence stakeholders for strategy development and execution (Heavey et al., 2020). When developing CEO social media celebrity, we build on this literature and consider the unique nature of celebrity within the social media environment, where we find CEOs are more likely to become celebrities through their direct communication (posting) with social media audiences.

Another contribution of our research is our application of parasocial interaction theory (Horton and Wohl, 1956; Stever, 2017). While parasocial interaction theory is widely studied in disciplines such as psychology (Giles, 2002) and marketing (Labrecque, 2014), our study is one of the first to consider it in the management literature. Given the proliferation and broad use of communication platforms that facilitate direct communication between managers and large audiences, the theory has growing relevance for understanding how managers influence the social evaluations of audiences both within and outside their firms. For our study, we assert that not unlike a movie star who builds a base of adoring fans by the way they present themselves to the public, CEOs can attract positive attention from a large social media audience – that is, achieve social media celebrity – by how they present themselves and foster parasocial interactions on the social media platform. Specifically, we find that the volume of posts and the positivity and variety of post content relate positively to CEO social media celebrity. We also find that the nature of posting has different relationships with the two dimensions of CEO social media celebrity, with posting volume having a more powerful relationship with the size of the audience attention, and positivity having a stronger connection to the emotional reactions of the audience on the social media platform.

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We believe our research offers practical implications for CEOs. Our findings suggest that CEOs can enhance the way they are socially evaluated on social media by maintaining a strong presence through frequent posting. CEOs also reap advantages by following more nuanced content creation strategies in the form of being positive in their messaging and keeping their content fresh by posting about a variety of topics. Finally, we find that a CEO social media celebrity is associated with a CEO celebrity in the mainstream media, which has been shown to lead to numerous career and firm benefits (Graffin et al., 2008; Wade et al., 2006, 2008) that we discuss in greater depth in our suggestions for future research, which we turn to now.

Limitations and Future Research Directions

Our study is not without limitations, many of which we believe provide future research opportunities. For example, our examination of social media audience reactions is limited to users' public posts, which may not align with their private opinions. While we hope that using social media sources to study celebrity, as Zavaylova et al. (2017) note, 'nonetheless provide valuable information about individuals' views that may be consequential for an organization' (p. 476), being able to understand the audience's inner beliefs would offer meaningful insights. Due to data availability, we could not examine the nature of the audience further (e.g., gender, affiliation with the CEO's firm), nor could we access the CEO's social media followers, but perhaps this information is available on alternative social media platforms.

We were also limited to examining CEO social media celebrity using mentions of CEOs with X accounts. Alternatively, scholars might examine any mentions of CEOs. We did not do this because of the difficulty in validating whether the mentions truly reflected a CEO. For example, if Tim Cook were mentioned by name by an X user without directly referring to Tim Cook's X account, it would be difficult to validate whether the X user was indeed referring to Tim Cook, the CEO of Apple. To test this further, we manually coded over 1300 posts mentioning the names of 10 CEOs on X over a 2-year period and were only able to confirm in about a third of the cases that the post was intended for the CEO. In contrast, direct mentions (i.e., @CEO handle-based mentions) provide a more targeted and unambiguous signal of social media users' attention directed at the CEO, aligning more closely with our conceptualization of the CEO as a social media celebrity.

Another limitation concerns temporal considerations. Celebrity is not always durable; it can develop, wax, and wane over time (Zavyalova et al., 2017), but we only consider the likelihood of a CEO becoming a CEO social media celebrity. Future research could examine the durability of CEO social media celebrity. In particular, we encourage scholars to consider how negativity gains traction and goes viral on social media, potentially influencing audience reactions to the CEO's post in ways we did not examine in our study. Another temporal limitation of our study is that we could not examine the regularity with which CEOs post, that is, how their posts are spread out during the year. While we theorize that post volume indicates social media presence and the likelihood of being 'seen' by social media audiences, future studies could take a more fine-grained temporal look at CEOs' posting behaviours.

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The lack of support for our CEO content uniqueness hypotheses is also surprising. We predicted that uniqueness would relate positively to CEO social media celebrity, consistent with research suggesting that distinctive actions and atypicality help CEOs stand out and be of interest to journalists (Hayward et al., 2004; Lovelace et al., 2022). However, the relationship between CEO post uniqueness and CEO social media celebrity was insignificant in our study. Moreover, while we expected it to have a stronger positive effect on the positive emotional responses than on the attention of audiences, it was negatively related to the positive emotional response and unrelated to the attention of the audience. While care must be taken when interpreting insignificant and untheorized relationships, we surmise that they may stem from audience differences. Compared to business journalists who are incentivized to pay attention to CEOs' distinctiveness to find 'good stories' that attract mainstream media audiences (Lovelace et al., 2022), social media audiences are only incentivized by satisfying their own interests. It seems plausible that users do not systematically pay much attention to how a CEO communicates relative to other CEOs as they do to how the CEO communicates vis-à-vis the broader social media community. Moreover, if audiences are concerned with CEOs relative to other CEOs, their attention may be more drawn to CEOs who communicate similarly to other CEOs, as it may reinforce the CEO's image as a desired public figure. We encourage future research to consider these complexities. We also encourage scholars to delve more deeply into why our findings indicate that social media audiences seem to pay less attention to female CEOs than male CEOs. Indeed, our control variable of gender, an indicator of CEO atypicality (Lovelace et al., 2022), did not relate significantly to CEO social media celebrity or positive emotional responses of the audience, but related negatively to audience attention.

We also did not find evidence that the variety of a CEO's social media posts relates more positively to the positive emotional reactions of the audience than the amount of audience attention. Future research can study these non-findings further and consider whether social media users' emotional reactions are less driven by the variety of topics than by the nature of the topics CEOs post about. Scholars have considered the nature of topics such as professional disclosures on social media (Yup, 2021), but the research is still scant, and we expect that there is a fertile opportunity to learn more, which we believe may offer important theoretical and practical contributions.

Finally, we encourage future research to more deeply explore the relationship between CEO social media celebrity and CEO celebrity. Using a temporal approach, it would be interesting to unpack if and how one leads to the other. As a control in our main analysis, CEO celebrity relates positively to the likelihood of being a CEO social media celebrity. In our supplemental tests, we show CEO celebrity can also be an outcome of CEO social media celebrity. It is plausible that both are true, given that the mainstream media is likely to influence social media audiences and vice versa. However, a more nuanced study of how these relationships unfold, and how they affect outcomes, would provide meaningful insights, especially as mainstream media and social media become increasingly blurred (Call et al., 2022).

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CONCLUSION

This study opens the door to rethinking what it means to be a celebrity CEO in the digital age. By distinguishing CEO social media celebrity from traditional media-driven CEO celebrity and examining its drivers, we consider a different audience where CEOs may wield influence – vast online audiences compared to a limited community of journalists. Our findings reveal how CEOs might shape their social media celebrity by attracting attention and evoking positive emotional responses from audiences through their strategic posting behaviours, and that becoming a CEO social media celebrity can, in turn, lead to mainstream CEO celebrity. We also offer several suggestions for future research to advance the understanding of CEO social media celebrity, something we expect will become increasingly salient to the social evaluations of CEOs as social media platforms proliferate and evolve in the modern era.

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NOTES

[1] As we discuss in our methodology section, we define a 'mention' as occurring when users mention the CEO's account in their post. We did not include mentions that refer to CEOs by name only due to the difficulty in validating whether the names indeed refer to the CEO.

[2] CEO social media celebrity and CEO celebrity are also similar in that they both differ from the related concepts of fame, infamy, reputation, and status. Fame refers to capturing the attention of a large audience regardless of the emotional reaction, that is, 'being talked about' (Dodds et al., 2022), and infamy refers to capturing the attention of a large audience with a negative emotional response (Zavyalova et al., 2017). Reputation refers to being known and admired for contributions and performance relative to a referent group (Deephouse and Carter, 2005), such as a CEO who leads a firm that consistently outperforms analyst expectations. Status focuses less on output and more on social hierarchical standing (Pollock et al., 2019), such as the CEO's additional positions within and outside the organization (e.g., board chair, board seats at other firms).

[3] Twitter was launched in 2006, but we began sampling in 2009 due to its earlier limited popularity and the lack of key features such as hashtags and retweeting. In an untabulated analysis, we tested samples from 2006 to 2021 and found consistent results.

[4] While using LIWC for positive emotional responses may seem conservative due to the brevity of responses, this is offset by our focus on the prevalence and patterns of positive emotional responses, rather than the depth of emotional expression. LIWC's dictionary-based approach is well-suited for this analysis.

[5] In our sample, over 85 per cent of CEOs maintained consistent celebrity or non-celebrity across all four quarters of the year, and over 80 per cent exhibited this stability across 12 consecutive months. Given our focus on the correlation between specific posting activities and outcomes, we believe that measuring on an annual basis could help us filter out more transient celebrity.

[6] To validate our approach of using responses per post as a proxy, we reviewed a sample of randomly selected 20 CEOs from our sample and compared their number of responses per tweet (calculated from their most recent 20 tweets) with their current follower count. The mean responses per post was 281.58, with a standard deviation of 1237.58. For follower count, the mean was 1.06×10^7 and the standard deviation was 4.72×10^7. We conducted a Pearson correlation analysis, which revealed a strong positive correlation of 0.99. These results validate our approach and show that the number of responses per post effectively reflects relative engagement for CEOs across a range of follower counts.

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